

Learning objectives

In this lesson you will learn to:

- Define what is meant by the term 'utility software'
- Identify different types of utility software
- Describe the purpose of different types of utility software
- Select which utility software tool to use for a particular task.

For more information and additional student activities see Topic 3.2 of the student book.

Utility software

- Previously you have learned that there are two types of software - systems and applications. Operating systems are a type of systems software.
- Utility software is another type of system software, that:
 - adds functionality to a computer, improves its performance, or helps maintain its hardware or other software
 - performs a specific management task such as backup and recovery, disk clean up, compression or archiving.

Research task

- Your first activity today is to research some of the tools that are available to perform utility tasks.
- There are a huge array of free and proprietary tools for performing these tasks.
- The types of utility program you need to research are:
 - file repair/recovery software
 - backup/recovery software
 - file compression software
 - disk defragmentation software.

Choosing the right tool for the job

- It's important to select the right tool for the job. This is as true in computing as it is in life!
- You may need to select a utility program for a particular situation and explain why it is necessary.
- A laptop has starting running slowly. It takes a long time to open files so that they can be worked on. Identify and justify a utility software program to use in this case.
- Disk defragmentation might be necessary to move all of the files into contiguous storage on the hard disk in order to speed up access.

Wrap up: you have learned how to...

- ✓ Define what is meant by the term 'utility software'.
 - Small specialised program designed to perform specific maintenance tasks.
- ✓ Describe the purpose of different types of utility software.
 - File repair/recovery software – for when files may have become corrupted due to malfunction or cyberattack.
 - Backup/recovery software – to save a copy of the system in another place in case of hardware failure or attack, so that the most recent state of the system can be recovered later.
 - File compression software – to reduce file sizes in order to save space on a hard drive or for transmission.
 - Disk defragmentation software – to move fragmented files into contiguous space on the disk in order to free up larger blocks of continuous space and speed up file access.